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The Effectiveness of Mentoring Adolescent Girls: Targeting Underserved Communities in Chicago's South Suburbs

By

Robin L. Miles
B.A., Governors State University 2009
M.A., Governors State University 2011

Capstone Project

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Governors State University
University Park, Illinois 60484

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Dedication

To my Lord and Savior, Jesus Christ who made the way for me to be rooted and grounded in His will and purpose for my life. Without Him I would not have had the mind to complete this journey. To my loving husband of ten years, Thomas, for your love and all that you do to make it comfortable for me to pursue my dreams. You have supported me in all my endeavors without reservation and encouraged me to see them through. I could not have done this without you. To my mini me (daughter) Krystini, since you were born, you have been my inspiration for setting my goals higher and succeeding at each one to be an example for you as you continue to grow and pursue your own dreams. To our fur baby (dog), Tyler, your presence is pure joy. You have literally been by my side, early mornings, late nights, and at my feet by the dinner table. Your unconditional love covers my faults and limits my fears. To my family and close friends who have supported me in all my endeavors, I am grateful for the encouragement you gave throughout this process to. I Love you All!

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Table of Contents

Dedication i

Acknowledgments ii

Table of Contents iii

List of Tables and Figures vi

Abstract 2

Chapter I 3

Introduction 3

Statement of Problem 4

Purpose of the Study 5

Research Questions 6

Definition of Terms 6

Theoretical Framework 7

Chapter II 8

Literature Review 8

Physical Inactivity Plagues Adolescent Girls 8

The Perfect Image of Beauty 11

Culture Diversity or Social Acceptance 12

Conclusion 13

Chapter III 15

Methodology 15

Data Collection 17

Data Analysis Procedures 19

Chapter IV 21

Results 21

Program Structure 23

Social Issues.....25

Relationship Building.....29

Best Practices.....29

Accomplishments.....31

Funding.....33

Chapter V.....36

Discussion.....36

Strengths and Limitations.....39

Conclusions.....41

Recommendations.....41

References 43

Appendices 50

Appendix A.....50

Interview Questions.....50

Appendix B.....52

Permission Request Letter 52

Appendix C.....53

Site Permission Letter.....53

Appendix D.....54

Informational Letter.....54

Appendix E 55

Letter of Consent 55

Appendix F 58

Sample Excel Coding Table.....58

Appendix G.....59

Sample Code List Organization 59

Appendix H.....58

Sample Code List Categorization.....58

List of Tables and Figures

Table 1 – Characteristics/Demographics……22

Figure 1 – Key components of the effectiveness of mentoring adolescent girls……23

Table 2 – Program Structure…….……...……...24

Table 3 – Social Issues……27

Table 4 – Relationship Building…….30

Table 5 – Best Practices…….32

Table 6 – Accomplishments……...34

Table 7 – Funding Category……...……35

Abstract

The objective of this research was to identify the most effective mentoring strategies to combat social issues that adolescent females are faced with; and to explore the implementation of female-only mentoring programs in Chicago's southland communities. The current study used an exploratory, qualitative phenomenological approach and content analysis to analyze the data. Purposive sampling was used to obtain participants for this study. All participants were at least 18 years old. All participants were actively engaged in their girl mentoring program at the time of the study. The researcher conducted semi-structured interviews using open-end questions. To ensure validity and reliability of the findings, the researcher engaged in triangulation and intra-rater observation. Findings revealed six themes describing key codes of effective strategies of mentoring adolescent girls: program structure; social issues; relationship building; best practices; accomplishments; and funding. Consequently, the research aims to provide recommendations of strategies to implement in female mentoring programs for adolescent girls and seek funding to serve in Chicago's southland communities that are often underserved due to their geographical location.

Chapter I

Introduction

This study focuses on the Effective Strategies for Mentoring Adolescent Girls. Policy makers, community service providers, intervention researchers, and administrators have all taken a great interest in youth mentoring, promoting it as a prevention approach to juvenile delinquency (Tolan, Henry, Schoeny, Lovegrove & Nichols, 2014). Historically, youth programs were designed to support, counsel, and encourage high school youth in pursuit of a college education, direct them toward a career field, or to counsel troubled or delinquent youth to accept a more socially appropriate lifestyle (Maldonado, Quarles, Lacey, & Thompson 2008).

Today there are many different types of mentoring programs available to support every facet of a young person's environment including: family, church, school, community, and sports. "The goals of youth mentoring have broadened from redressing youth problems to promoting positive youth development" (Liang, Spencer, West & Rappaport, 2013, p. 257). The approach to mentoring adolescent girls has several variations due to the differences in circumstances. While the approach may be different, when implemented properly, the strategies of youth mentoring can produce positive effects for some young people (Rhodes, 2008).

While mentoring is used as a prevention approach to delinquency, mentoring programs can sometimes have minimal, if any, impact, particularly when there is not a clear vision and specific, targeted outcomes intended for the mentoring intervention. According to Jarjoura (2013), the ultimate goal is to provide adult mentors to support young people, enabling them to successfully make the transition to adulthood and become productively engaged adult citizens—law-abiding, connected to meaningful work, in healthy relationships, and living in healthy environments. In a model pertaining to ways that mentoring makes a difference, Jean Rhodes

(2002) suggests that mutuality, trust, and empathy are characteristics of effective mentoring relationships which are likely to contribute to positive youth outcomes if the relationships contribute to social-emotional development, cognitive development, and identity development of the youth.

When done well, mentoring can be transformative. Mentoring can motivate young people to pursue successful and productive futures, reaching their potential through positive relationships and the use of community resources (Jarjoura, 2013). Therefore, it is imperative for programs that provide mentors for youth to consider the best ways to structure their programs to maximize the likelihood that the relationship between the mentor and mentee will be transformative (Jarjoura, 2013).

This study looked for gaps in implementation strategies that focuses on different elements that help build the self-esteem of adolescent girls. Building self-esteem is essential to helping young girls to have confidence in themselves to make responsible decisions. Mentoring programs that use strategies to obstruct the factors involved with low self-esteem can produce long-term beneficial results among adolescent girls.

Statement of Problem

Scholars suggest that mentoring programs may have a greater impact on at-risk young people who have individual and environmental risk, compared to serving youth who were not experiencing either type of risk (Dubois & Silverthorn, 2005). Youth are faced with numerous problems which put them in the category of ‘at-risk’. Poverty, single parent homes, learning disabilities, and dangerous neighborhoods, are some of the problems which raise issues of low self-esteem, obesity, fear, and building good relationships among adolescent females. These at-risk situations do not only occur in urban communities; but there are many suburban

communities that face these issues. Some suburban communities are limited in their resources and are not always able to provide programs that will help resolve these issues. These issues can often lead to problems in societal epidemics resulting in teenage pregnancy, gang violence, drug abuse, bullying, juvenile delinquency, murder, and suicide and mental illnesses.

Many adolescent females face alarming high rates of suspension, expulsion, and dropping out of high school. They are less likely to pursue a college education, and some end up bearing children with absent fathers. Consequently, some are likely to cycle into the welfare system and struggle with substance abuse, behavior problems, mental illness, and emotional issues such as overeating and depression (Jarjoura, 2013). The National Mentoring Partnership argues that "mentoring is one of the most widely used approaches for such problems with thousands of organizations in the United States offering some form of this approach" (as cited in Tolan et al., 2014, p. 180)

Purpose of the Study

The purpose of this study is to identify the most effective mentoring strategies that are being implemented by not-for-profit, female only youth mentoring programs in Chicago southland. Because it is anticipated that mentoring will transform, inspire and guide young people to pursue successful and productive futures; it could be beneficial for adolescent girls to be involved in mentoring programs that will help them build their confidence and reach their potential through positive relationships and utilization of community resources. Because of the many facets of youth mentoring, there is no exhaustive inquiry pertaining to the effective strategies of mentoring. This research looks for gaps in program strategies to develop the best strategies that will produce long-term positive effects form mentoring adolescent girls. Anyone desiring to implement such programs would benefit from further research.

Research Questions

Rhodes (2008) suggests that "A better understanding of the research evidence for youth mentoring, including findings from reviews, evaluations and meta-analyses, provides a basis for more informed, practically applicable approach to strengthening youth mentoring interventions" (p. 35). For this study, the following questions will be addressed:

1. What are the best practices currently being implemented by female only mentoring programs?
2. How do female only mentoring programs evaluate accomplishments?
3. What benchmarks are used most often by female only mentoring programs to secure funding?

Definition of Terms

1. Mentoring – "a relationship between an older, more experienced adult and an unrelated, younger protégé – a relationship in which the adult provides ongoing guidance, instruction, and encouragement aimed at developing the competence and character of the protégé" (Rhodes, 2002, p. 3).
2. Adolescent – a young person living out the second decade of life that marks various developmental changes such as puberty and cognitive development (Darling, 2005).
3. Mentor – "an older, more experienced person who seeks to further the development of character and competence in a younger person by guiding the latter in acquiring mastery of progressively more complex demonstration, instruction challenge, and encouragement on a more or less regular basis over an extended period of time" (as cited in Dubois & Karcher, 2005, p. 4).

4. Mentoring Relationship – connotes "a special bond between an inexperienced or naïve student and someone more skilled than him or her who is willing to act as a guide in a new or unfamiliar situation" (Hamilton & Darling, 1996, p. 202).

Theoretical Framework

The most appropriate theory for this study is Similarity/Attraction Theory. Researchers from a variety of fields such as marketing, political science, social psychology have contributed to and gleaned from information from empirical tests of similarity/attraction theory since the mid 1900's. The theory provides a framework for examining how and why people are attracted to and influenced by others in their social worlds. Scholars suggests that program developers and researchers should test hypotheses regarding the influences of mentoring program elements based on theory-driven expectations about the interrelationships among proximal, enabling, and distal outcomes of mentoring programs, in order to understand better how and under what conditions mentoring works (Karcher, Kupermink, Portwood, Siper & Taylor, 2006).

The similarity/attraction theory indicates that people like and are attracted to others who are similar, rather than dissimilar, to themselves (Berscheid & Walster 1969; Byrne 1971). In addition to people's inclinations to be attracted to those who share similar attitudes, people are also attracted to others who manifest personality characteristics (e.g., optimism, self-esteem, shyness, conscientiousness) that are similar to their own (Berscheid and Walster 1969; Byrne 1971). As applied to this study, this theory holds the independent variable, implementation of effective mentoring programs, will influence or explain the dependent variables, that when strategies used in mentoring relationships are implemented properly, mentoring programs can have long-term positive effects on adolescent girls because they may want to apply what they

learn from those relationships and experiences with their mentors to their current and future endeavors.

Chapter II

Literature Review

This review of published literature examines qualitative and quantitative studies that suggest strategies for implementing effective mentoring programs for adolescent girls and focuses on physical fitness, beauty, social acceptance, and cultural diversity. The literature is examined to make a connection with the implementation of strategies used to combat individual and environmental issues that adolescent girls experience. Many adolescent girls lack the proper support of others who may be influential in helping young girls to develop confidence and raise awareness about their physical health, natural beauty, and acceptance of oneself. Having the tools to properly apply these aspects in life can help adolescent girls build self-esteem and make responsible decisions to avoid teen pregnancy, drug use, gang violence, bullying, juvenile delinquency, and suicide. Cavendish, Montague, Enders, and Dietz (2014) found that family system theory has been an integral source in understanding and explaining the ecological nature of families, as well as the dynamics among family members. The adolescent girls growing up in poor communities, in mother only households, low in-come status, with multiple siblings are predicted to have very limited opportunities or resources (Kennedy, 2007). Mentoring programs that use strategies to obstruct the factors involved with low self-esteem may produce long-term beneficial results among adolescent girls.

Physical Inactivity Plagues Adolescent Girls

The physical and emotional effects of physical activities lead to good health and well-being. Physical fitness influences the emotional state of being and can help a person to look, feel,

and do their best. While physical fitness produces beneficial results for good health and well-being; Raudsepp and Viira (2008) noted that the prevalence of obesity is increasing at an alarming rate in children and adolescents worldwide. Insufficient amount of physical activity is hypothesized to be an important contributing factor in the development and/or maintenance of childhood obesity (Weinsier, Hunter, Heini, Goran, & Sell, 1998).

Influencing physical activity and good health behaviors can be effective ways to implement successful mentoring programs. Childhood obesity is progressively on the rise mainly due to inadequate amounts of physical activities and unhealthy eating habits. Today, many children spend too much time being inactive due to the increasing popularity of electronic devices. Smartphones, computers, and video games offer just about everything that would strike a young person's interest. However, these devices require little to no physical effort to use. These gadgets take away their motivation to want to engage in physical activities.

Young people lack motivation for physical fitness when their efforts are not socially supported. Social support, generally referring to any behavior that assists an individual in achieving desired goals or outcomes, is important in relation to physical activity (Sallis, Prochaska, & Taylor, 2000; Duncan, Duncan, & Strycker, 2005). Studies in the physical activity domain have demonstrated the importance of peer or friend support in physical activity and found numerous studies pointing to the potential benefits of activity-related support from family and friends among youth (Davison & Schmalz, 2006; Duncan, Duncan, & Strycker, 2005, 2007). Different levels of physical activity in young adolescent girls vary in connection to supervised and unsupervised after school time (Rushovich, et al., 2006). Adult presence would be positively associated with physical activity among young adolescent girls, whereas adult absence would

cause girls to engage in behaviors that are sedentary such as watching television and talking on the telephone (Rushovich, et al., 2006).

In their efforts to measure activities of the Trial of Activity for Adolescent Girls (TAAG), Rushavich et al. (2006) used a random sample of girls from 36 middle schools at six field sites across the U.S. to participate. Information was collected using six-day objectively measured physical activity, self-reported physical activity using a three-day recall, and socioeconomic and psychosocial measures. Sallis, Prochaska & Taylor (2000) conducted a comprehensive review of correlates of physical activity, and semi-quantitative results were summarized separately for children (ages 3–12) and adolescents (ages 13–18). Of a sample of 108 people, 40 variables were evaluated for children and 48 variables for adolescents. As a result, 60% of all reported associations with physical activity were statistically significant (Sallis, Prochaska & Taylor, 2000).

Scholars agree that variables such as ethnicity, perceived activity competence, opportunities to exercise, free/reduced lunch programs, neighborhood resources, community sports, parent support and support from others were consistently associated with adolescents' physical activity (Rushavich et al., 2006; Sallis, Prochaska &Taylor, 2000). "These results may have implications for parents, school, and community agencies as to how to structure activities in order to encourage teenage girls to be more physically active" (Rushavich et al., 2006, p. 321).

Sallis, Prochaska & Taylor (2000) suggested more studies should confirm these consistently related variables, and interventions to improve the modifiable variables should be developed and evaluated. Adult supervision adds positive support and will cause girls to be more involved in physical activities. Implementing after-school and other mentoring programs can add

to this support by offering sports and fitness activities that will keep adolescent girls motivated and active.

The Perfect Image of Beauty

The goal of mentoring adolescent girls in beauty is to bring awareness of the perfect image of beauty that they already possess. Body image is central to adolescent girls' self-definition, because they have been socialized to believe that appearance is an important basis for self-evaluation and for evaluation by others (Thompson, Heinberg, Altabe, & Tantleff-Dunn, 1999). Another study, Clay, Vignoles and Dittmar (2005) used a sample of 135 U.K. girls ages 11-16 from a single-sex state school to show that "experimental exposure to either ultra-thin or average-size magazine models lowered body satisfaction and, consequently, self-esteem" (p. 452). The study measured awareness and internalization of sociocultural attitude toward appearance, social comparison with media models, body satisfaction and self-esteem.

McCabe, Ricciardelli, and Ridge (2006) conducted a detailed evaluation of the nature of the messages received by adolescents about their bodies from various sociocultural agents (e.g., parents, peers, and media) and examined the way the messages were interpreted, including the internal dialogue associated with such messages. Gordon (2008) used data from a survey of 176 African American adolescent girls ages 13-17 from a predominantly African American high school in a large Midwestern city to examine associations between Black media use and African American girls' focus on beauty and appearance. Results suggest that exposure to and identification with images of Black women in mass media plays a significant role in influencing African American adolescent girls with emphasis on appearance (Gordon 2008).

The mass media are reported to be an important sociocultural influence on body image among adolescent girls; and studies have demonstrated that perceived pressure from the media to

lose weight is an important predictor of body dissatisfaction among adolescent girls. (Thompson & Heinberg, 1999; McCabe & Ricciardelli, 2003)

Images of women dominating the media can potentially limit girls' self-perceptions and influence their attitudes regarding the importance of appearance (Gordon, 2008). How one views the way they look and confidence are inextricably connected, such that perceived appearance consistently emerges as the strongest single predictor of self-esteem among both male and female adolescents (Clay, Vignoles, & Dittmar, 2005).

These studies show that social influence, especially mass media, has a dominating effect on how adolescent girls perceive the image of perfect beauty and suggest early educational interventions to help girls to deconstruct advertising and media images (Gordon, 2008; Clay, Vignoles & Dittmar, 2006). Mentoring programs can provide information and teach girls how to perceive their own natural beauty and learn how to be confident in maintaining it.

Culture Diversity or Social Acceptance

Some elements of cultural diversity focus on socialization. Awareness of individual differences is prevalent in every society. Cultural influence on children is inspired by the family; other sources of influence include school, church, media, and friends. Research has shown that race, class, gender, and other diversities are intersecting systems which are experienced simultaneously (Beck, Williams, Hope & Parks, 2001; Anderson & Hill Collins, 2001). It is important that adolescent girls are made aware of the fact that differences in people do exist; and learn how to cope with the challenges of being different.

Karen Hurtes (2002) conducted a qualitative study using focus groups and participant observations to identify the critical elements of adolescent girls' culture and the impact of this culture on social behavior. Participants were 15-year-old girls involved in a voluntary leadership

training program at a summer residential camp in the Northeast. While focus group discussions revealed adolescent girls' reality; the participant observation portion discovered behavioral distinctions and found that relatedness (social acceptance) is, by far, the most critical concern for adolescent girls (Hurtes, 2002).

Social dependency is the true reality of adolescent girls and noted as the idea of their culture because of its level of significance and its ability to explain perceived and actual reality (Hurtes, 2002). The American Association of University Women released a study that identifies "fitting in" as one of four major issues facing girls today; other issues were societal messages to girls, sexuality and school (AAUW, 1999). While it is the desire of most adolescent girls to belong, some will not. Partly because of their high level of self-consciousness regarding physical appearance, adolescent girls typically restrict their behavior to conform to social norms to fit in (Hurtes, 2002). Scholars agree that girls need the feeling of being supported to participate in physical and leisure activity (Rushavich et al., 2006; Sallis, Prochaska &Taylor, 2000; Hurtes, 2002).

While seeking social acceptance is important, one's culture must remain prevalent throughout adolescent years as it reinforces one's identity. "Facilitators working with adolescent girls should seek training that is specific to the issues identified by and faced by girls to increase awareness and sensitivity" (Hurtes, 2002, p. 119). Mentoring programs will assist in teaching adolescent girls how to maintain their own identity while fitting in or while being teased for their differences.

Conclusion

This review of literature consistently shows the need for early educational interventions to help build self-esteem, awareness, and acceptance of oneself among adolescent girls.

Implementing these interventions through mentoring programs can reduce teen pregnancy, drug abuse, gang violence, bullying, suicide and other societal issues that plague adolescent girls.

Even though adolescent youth face numerous problems, this literature focuses on specific areas where common problems would occur: physical health, natural beauty, and acceptance of oneself. Evidence shows that unless friends and/or family motivate adolescent girls, it is unlikely that they will voluntarily become physically active; they will be comfortable with their sedentary behaviors that can eventually lead to obesity and low self-esteem.

Adolescent girls view the world by what they are involved in, and if they are sitting around watching television and talking on the telephone, then they will be drawn by what they see and hear. Eventually their perception of life would begin to change, and they will want to become what their environment dictates to them. Ultimately, they can lose their identity, and it would be hard for them to accept their natural selves. Erikson's (1959) suggested that if the development stages are not successfully completed, then maladaptive behavior is likely to follow and persist. The adolescent stage of development, if successfully completed, yields positive outcomes related to fidelity and devotion (Cherry, 2015; Erikson, 1959).

Young people need guidance especially young girls during the adolescent ages of 11 – 17. Mentors can play an important role in promoting resilience among children and adolescents. Knowledge and skills can be attained successfully through mentor and mentee relationships that produce positive effects. Positive effects can only occur when both parties are satisfied with the results of the relationship.

It is apparent that more research is needed in mentoring to understand the basic elements of how mentoring works, and to assess the benefits of mentoring programs for adolescent girls. "Developing a more comprehensive understanding of and response to adolescent girls' needs

should make it possible to create the best possible recreation environments through which their emic needs can be met" (Hurtes, 2002, p. 119). A study on natural mentoring relationships found that formal mentoring programs had a strong effect on youth who experienced both individual and environmental risk (Dubois and Siverthorn, 2005). Mentoring relationships can produce long-term beneficial results when the mentor is willing to focus on meeting the needs of the mentee, and the mentee is willing to accept the guidance and apply it to their lives.

Chapter III

Methodology

The current study used an exploratory, qualitative phenomenological approach and content analysis to analyze the data. Qualitative research is a scientifically based method of research for systematically exploring and understanding the meaning individuals or groups attribute to a social or human problem (Creswell & Creswell, 2018). The qualitative research process involves developing questions and procedures; collecting data through in-depth interviews, questionnaires and surveys; analyzing the data inductively; building from large amounts of details to general themes; and interpreting the meaning of data (Creswell, 2014). This study was designed to understand the experiences of mentoring program directors and youth mentors, and their perspective of how female mentoring programs implement strategies that may have long-term positive effects on adolescent girls. Research suggest that the best practices of what to do may be clear (Garringer et al., 2015), but the question of how to do it is less known (Larsen et.al., 2016). Consequently, the question guiding this study is how we can facilitate best practices of female mentoring programs for adolescent girls and create conditions for these programs to strive and become effectively instrumental in girl's growth and development.

Creswell and Creswell (2018) states that phenomenological research is a qualitative strategy in which the research identifies the essence of human experiences about a phenomenon as described by participants in a study. Phenomenon-driven research focuses on capturing, documenting, and conceptualizing an observed phenomenon of interest to facilitate knowledge creation and develop new contributions to organizational change debates (Schwarz & Stensaker, 2016). This study used a qualitative phenomenological approach to explore the experiences of program directors and youth mentors from different mentoring organizations in Chicago's southland by conducting open-ended semi-structured interviews to investigate the need for mentoring programs for adolescent girls. Additionally, the research aims to provide recommendations of strategies to implement in female mentoring programs for adolescent girls and how to seek funding to serve in Chicago's southland communities that are often underserved compared to Chicago's urban areas where youth programs are in abundance. The benefit of conducting qualitative phenomenological research is that the questions in the interviews are not limited to structured answers, which allows the researcher to probe for more detailed information.

Content analysis is used for analyzing text data to provide knowledge and understanding of the phenomenon under study (Hsieh & Shannon, 2005; Downe-Wamboldt, 1992). Scholars define content analysis as "a means to congregate text into categories using systematic, replicable techniques using specific rules of coding" (as cited in Clark 2003, p. 54). Content analysis is more than counting words, it also offers intense examination of language to categorize large amounts of text that have similar meaning (Weber, 1990). In this study a detailed analysis of the data from the interview transcripts is interpreted through a systematic format based on the organization of codes and themes derived from the participants responses.

Data Collection

There are five interrelated steps in the process of qualitative data collection. First identify participants and sites to be studied and to engage in a sampling strategy that will best help to understand the central phenomenon and the research question being asked. Second, the next phase is to gain access to these individuals and sites by obtaining permissions. Third, once permissions are in place, consider what types of information will best answer the research questions. Fourth, at the same time, the researcher needs to design protocols or instruments for collecting and recording the information. Finally, and fifth, the researcher needs to administer the data collection with special attention to potential ethical issues that may arise.

Participants and Permissions

Purposive sampling, a common sampling strategy in qualitative research, was used to obtain participants for this study. Purposive sampling is a process of identifying and selecting individuals or groups of individuals who are available to reflectively articulate their knowledge of and experience with the phenomenon that is being explored (Palinkas et al., 2013; Patton, 2002; Bernard 2002). In a qualitative phenomenological study, the researcher often conducts a minimum of five interviews to build a sufficient dataset to look for common themes and to use other participants to validate findings (Schwarz & Stensaker, 2016). Human participants, specifically, program directors and mentors from female only mentoring programs for adolescent girls in Chicago's southland – Country Club Hills, Homewood, Olympia Field, Harvey, and Beecher were selected to participate in an individual interview.

The researcher sent emails to the mentoring organizations requesting their permission to recruit their program directors/mentors and to conduct the interviews on their premises if necessary. Once the requests were granted, the researcher invited a total of ten program directors

and mentors to participate in the study by emailing an informational letter and consent form. Of the ten invited, two program directors and three mentors from five different female youth programs were recruited and required to sign and return the consent form before participating in the study. The age of consent was 18 year and older. All the participants were at least 18 years old. Upon agreement to participate, a date and time to meet was set and followed by a confirming email. When it was not convenient to meet at the organization's facility, a designated place was mutually agreed upon by the researcher and the program coordinator or mentor. All the participants were actively engaged in their girl mentoring program at the time of the study.

Instrumentation

Qualitative interviews generally involve open-ended questions that are intended to elicit views and opinions from the participants through face-to-face interviews, interviews by telephone, email/internet interviews, or by engaging in focus group interviews (Creswell & Creswell, 2018). The researcher conducted five individual semi-structured interviews using open-end questions that were developed prior to the interviews. The interviews focused on the participants perspectives of 1). the measurement of their program's success; 2). how program funding is secured for the program; and 3). information regarding strategies that are implemented in their programs that can be useful to other adolescent girl mentoring programs in suburban communities. The open-ended question not only allowed the participants to share their knowledge and experience related to the content being focused on, but also allowed the research to probe beyond the script when new themes emerged.

After three face-to-face interviews were complete, the original request to gain permission to meet in person changed because of the global pandemic crisis, COVID-19. During the time of

the study, a government stay-at-home order demanded Illinoisans to conduct all non-essential business at home to slow down the spread of the disease starting March 2020 through June 2020. Once the order was lifted residents continued to follow social distance measures for protection from spread of the disease. Consequently, of the remaining two interviews, one was conducted over the telephone and the other through an agreed upon video conferencing platform. The interviews were recorded, after receiving permission from the participant, and field notes were written by the researcher. The interviews lasted between 45 and 60 minutes and the researcher extended a verbal thank you and the end of each interview. This study used open-ended questions (Appendix A) during the interviews to investigate.

Ethical Issues

The current study posed minimal risks to the participants. As stated in the signed consent forms, the participants were not required to record their names or any identifiable information, they were free to opt out of the study at any time, and the information that they provided would be confidential and used only for the purpose of this study. The consent form also stated that only the researcher would have access to the data and that all the data would be kept confidential in a locked file cabinet in the researcher home. Upon completion of the study all data, recorded and written will be destroyed. A proposal of the research was present to and approved by the Institutional Review Board (IRB) in advance to protect the rights of human participants according to the IRB standards.

Data Analysis Procedures

The qualitative data was analyzed using conventional content analysis to interpret the meaning of the language in the transcribed data through a process of coding and identifying themes or patterns (Hsieh & Shannon, 2005). Throughout the analysis process, the research

employs Creswell's (2014) six steps to analyzing data. First, the interview data were organized and transcribed (Creswell 2014). Second, the researcher read through all the data to identify the tone, general ideas, and credibility (Creswell, 2014). Next, the coding process involved placing the transcribed text data into categories and labeling them (Creswell, 2014).

The researcher read through the focus questions and broke them up to determine the how to identify the codes. A Microsoft Excel table was created to record the codes for each participant see (Appendix F). Once the codes were recorded individually, they were combined to correspond with the emerging themes and then listed in a Microsoft Word document to continue the process (Appendix G). The researcher manually compiled the codes in Microsoft Word and then arranged them alphabetically to determine code frequency. Code frequency was indicated by a number in parenthesis to the right of each code. A trial version of NVivo data analysis software was also used to record word frequency. The lists of codes were reduced and consolidated, then sorted into color coded labeled clusters (Appendix H).

In the fourth step of the coding process, a description of themes and categories were generated for analysis (Creswell, 2014). The researcher established how the findings from the analysis would be represented in the fifth step (Creswell, 2014). The findings in the current study are represented by visuals (i.e. tables, charts) to assist in the discussion of the findings. Finally, in the sixth step the researcher interpreted the data to report what was learned from the findings (Creswell, 2014). In comparison to the qualitative data analysis, the research was able to also derive meaning from the literature. Organizing and breaking everything up into correct categories allowed validity of accuracy to be established at each step of the analysis process (Creswell, 2014).

To ensure validity and reliability of the findings, the researcher engaged in triangulation and intra-rater observation. Qualitative validity focuses on accuracy, while qualitative reliability focuses on consistency (Creswell, 2014). For this study, the researcher provided a detailed account of the procedures. Triangulation, a significant validation strategy, was used to examine evidence from various types of data, drawing on multiple viewpoints (Creswell, 2014). Interviews, online research, book, and literature reviews regarding mentoring adolescent girls were used to triangulate the findings in this study. Intra-rater observation is a reliability strategy where an individual observer of a phenomenon has "the ability to consistently get the same results when making observations at different times" (Dowd, 2019, para. 1) The researcher reviewed and coded the interview data twice, one week apart, using clean copies of text data each time and consistently coded the data the same way each time. Data collection and analysis strategies were reported in detail order

Chapter IV

Results

Participants were from five mentoring organizations in the southland region of Chicago, Illinois (Country Club Hills, n=1; Homewood, n=1; Olympia Fields, n=1; South Suburbs, n=1; and Beecher, n=1). All five organizations had mentoring programs that focused on adolescent girls. Two (40%) of the organizations were community-based programs that have been in existence for 14 and 13 years; two (40%) were church programs that have been in existence for 20 and five years; and one (20%) was a high school program that has been in existence for three years. The participants were asked several background questions regarding their experience as a mentor. All five participants indicated that they served in the role of mentor, and two of the five also served as program directors. The two program directors had the longest years served, one 13

and the other 14. The other three mentors served for two, four, and five years. Demographic data are shown in Table 1.

Findings revealed six themes describing key codes of effective strategies of mentoring adolescent girls. These included (1) program structure; (2) social issues; (3) relationship building; (4) best practices; (5) accomplishments; and (6) funding (see Figure 1). The themes are listed in the order of code frequency with which they appeared in the interview data. All themes appeared in all five interviews. As described earlier, the interviews focused on the participants perspectives of 1). the measurement of their program's success; 2). how program funding is secured for the program; and 3). information regarding strategies that are implemented in their programs that can be useful to other adolescent girl mentoring programs in suburban communities. Comments gleaned from the interview transcripts are listed in the tables that correspond with the themes.

Table 1
Characteristics of Youth Mentors and Youth Mentoring Organizations Demographics

	MENTORS		MENTORING PROGRAM		
Table 1 1					
Mentoring Participants	Participants Role in the Program	Mentors # of Years Served	Type of Program	Location	# of Years in Existence
Participants 1	Program Director Mentor	14	Community Based	Country Club Hills Illinois	14
Participants 2	Program Director Mentor	5	Church	Homewood, Illinois	5
Participants 3	Mentor	2	High School	Olympia Field	3
Participants 4	Program Director Mentor	13	Community Based/Mobile	Chicago Southland	13

Participants				Beecher,	
5	Mentor	4	Church	Illinois	20

Figure 1
Key components of the effectiveness of mentoring adolescent girls.

Program Structure

Mentor responses to interview questions regarding program structure generated 19 key codes. From the 17 key codes, four thematic categories were identified: Program Participants, Pre-program Assessment, Post-program Assessment and Program Changes. Mentor responses indicated that the programs target population consisted of “girl, ages 8-18,” with some programs having an “emphasis on at-risk girls impacted by high crime neighborhood,” and others said their programs “welcome all races and ethnicities.

Assessments conducted before and after the program were also part of the program structure. Two major components of the assessments were: Desire to participate and Monitoring growth and maturity. One of the mentors interviewed stated that “we make sure they have a desire to join so that they can get the most out of the program.” Another mentor stated that “we do a character assessment and check growth progress to determine if they will return for the next season.”

Participant feedback and the mentor-to-mentee were the highest frequency codes showing reasons for changing the program stucture. One mentor stated the “we look for feedback from our participants on how they would like to see the program change,” another stated that “we need enough volunteers to at least cover each age group.” The key codes and thematic categories for program structure are presented in Table 2.

Table 2
Content Analysis Results for Program Structure

Thematic Category	Key Codes	Code frequency	Sample responses
Program Participants			Q1. What is the target population of your mentoring organization?
	Ages 8-18	4	Girls ages 8-18.
	Open to all races	2	So far, we have African American girls, but we welcome all races and ethnicities.
	At-risk youth	2	Emphasis on at-risk girls impacted by high crime neighborhoods.
	Females	2	We target young ladies.
Pre-program assessment			Q.2 What intake assessments do you make before enrolling girls in the program?
	Desire to participate	5	We make sure they have a desire to join so they can get the most out of the program.
	Family dynamics	3	We evaluated family dynamics to predetermine outcomes.

	Evaluate Talent	3	We can better determine where to put them if we know what talents they possess.
	Participant Expectations	1	Our girls are asked to list their expected outcomes at the time of registration.
Post-program assessment			Q3. What post-program assessments do you make after participants complete the program?
	Monitor growth and maturity	4	We do character assessment and check growth progress to determine if they will return for the next season.
	Continue mentoring post program	4	The mentors are available to assist with employment and to help them transition to the next level.
	Demonstrate acquired skills	3	We look for demonstration of the skills that they learn from the program.
	Participation Survey	1	We do evaluation surveys so the girls can express their thoughts about the program.
Reasons to change program			Q4. What would cause the structure of your program to change?
	Participant feedback	5	We look for feedback from our participants on how they would like to see the program change.
	Mentor to Mentee ratio	4	We need enough volunteers to at least cover each age
	Monetary resources	2	Another thing that would cause our program to change is if we had more money to work with.
	Level of growth	2	If we do not see any growth, we would reevaluate the program to make changes.
	Previous year's activities	1	We always look for ways to improve our events and activities

Social Issues

Combatting social issues generated four thematic categories from 29 key codes. The categories were: Social Issues, Health and Fitness, Self-Esteem, and Beauty Influences. Fitting in and peer pressure ranked high among the social issues. All five participants commented on fitting in, and one stated “peer pressure and the need to fit are some of the biggest issues that we

deal with." Other participant responses generated codes of "bullying, drugs, academics, behavior, and etiquette" as pertaining to social issues plaguing adolescent girls.

The health and fitness category was generated out of combatting social issues because of the concern to raise awareness about girls physical and nutritional health. Two key codes, Meal Prep and Fitness Techniques, and Promote Healthy Eating had the same frequency. Participants stated that "we bring in health and fitness experts to teach the girls new techniques such and exercise and meal prep," and "we are a part of the Food Depository which helps us to promote healthy eating in our community."

Self-esteem was generated from eight key codes indicating a difference between girls with high self-esteem and girls with low self-esteem. Mentor responses revealed that some of the girl are "defensive and bold when it comes to discussions and issues that they deal with." Another mentor stated that "these young ladies display high confidence in all the group settings, these two comments stood out to imply a high level of self-esteem when it comes to being a part of a group. Other responses focused low self-esteem due to family structure, low confidence, and nervousness. One mentor stated that "some of the girls pull back a little because in their family structure, they experience lack" others responded, "they demonstrate low confidence in their ability to succeed," and "girls who are home schooled are a little nervous about discussions because they do not have as much exposure." These comments indicate low self-esteem may be a result of their environment or experiences.

Beauty influences was generated from nine key codes. This theme stood out as a social issue because it focuses on how girls define beauty and who/what influences them the most. Clothes, shoes, hair, makeup, nails, social media, humor, personal appearance and peer and celebrity influence had the highest code frequency in this category. Mentors responded, "from

the youngest to the oldest, our girls are intrigued by hair and makeup and clothing styles," and "they are big on personal appearance and value each other's approval." Mentors also stated, "they laugh a lot, so humor is their definition of beauty" and they are "mostly influenced by their mentor, celebrities, and social media." Beauty influence had the highest code frequency among the key codes under social issues. The thematic categories and key code for social issue are presented in Table 3.

Table 3
Content Analysis Results for Combatting Social Issues

Thematic Category	Key Codes	Code frequency	Sample responses
Social Issues			What social issues concerning adolescent girls do you target in your program?
	Fitting in	5	I am currently mentoring one who struggles with fitting in.
	Peer pressure,	4	Peer pressure and the need to fit are some of the biggest issued that we deal with.
	Bullying, drugs, academics, behavior, wellness, and etiquette	3	We deal with peer pressure, bully drugs, academics, behavior, wellness, and etiquette.
	Poverty	2	We have implemented our program in impoverished areas so that we can reach girls from different backgrounds
	Respect for self and others	2	We work on skills to help us give respect the same respect that we deserve.
	Depression	1	There is one who suffers from depression,
	Parent incarceration	1	We have a program that gives to children whose parents are incarcerated
	Relationships	1	Some of the girls will discuss their relationship with the opposite sex whenever they feel comfortable.
	Teen pregnancy	1	I was able to encourage a girl who thought she would be pregnant within a year, she got pregnant three years late, so it worked.
	Social media use	1	We discuss the use of social media to avoid predatory activity.

Health and Fitness			What strategies do you use to raise awareness concerning girl's physical and nutritional health?
	Meal prep and fitness techniques	5	We bring in health and fitness experts to teach the girls new techniques such as exercises and meal preps.
	Promote healthy eating	5	We are a part of the Food Depository program which helps us to implement healthy eating in our community.
Self-Esteem			Describe the self-esteem levels of the girls in your program.
	Bold	3	They are defensive and bold when it comes to discussions and issues that they deal with.
	Lack in Family structure	4	Some of the girls pull back a little because in their family structure they experience some lack.
	Low confidence	2	They demonstrate low confidence in their ability to succeed.
	Low self-esteem	2	Self-esteem is low among our youth.
	Retain everything	2	The girls are like magnets, they soak up everything they see, hear, and are taught.
	Lack initiative	2	The rarely take initiative and always need assistance.
	High confidence	1	These young ladies display high confidence on all levels.
	Nervous	1	Some girls who are homeschooled are a little nervous about discussions because they do not have as much exposure.
Beauty Influences			Describe how the girls in your program define beauty and what influences that most.
	Clothes, shoes	5	From the youngest to the oldest, our girls are intrigued by hair and makeup and clothing style.
	Social media influence	5	They turn to social media for the
	Hair, makeup, nails	5	Hair, makeup, fingernails, clothes, shoes,
	Personal appearance	4	They are big on personal appearance, and value each other's approval.
	Beauty in humor	2	One thing I have noticed is that they laugh a lot, so humor is their definition of beauty.
	Peer influence	2	They are greatly influenced by each other.
	Celebrity and mentor influence	2	Mostly influenced by their mentor, celebrities, and social media.

New trends	1	They are big on social media for the new trends and everything.
Beauty within	1	We always talk about the beauty within being their most important asset.

Relationship Building

Relationship building generated 14 key codes and from that two thematic categories were generated. The two categories were, Mentor-Mentee Relationships and Peer Relationships. Both thematic categories focus on how the relationships are formed. The top code frequency for mentor-mentee relationships was conscious of girls' interest, engaging one another, demographics, and social stability. Regarding relations building, one mentor stated that "I always ask them how they are doing in certain areas that concern them," another mentor commented "I engage them through conversation and encouragement." Other mentor perceptions on how mentor/mentee relationships are built are "gender, age, and personalities so they can relate better with each other," and "maintaining neutrality, and avoiding conflict."

Having mutual goals, supporting each other, and learning from each other are among the most frequent codes for how peer relationships are built among girls in the program. Interview responses from mentors regarding peer relationships included "grouping them so that they all have the same goals," "sisterhood and finding things in common through support," and "they are intrigued by each other's skill set and want to learn from each other. The thematic categories and key code for relationship building are presented in Table 4.

Best Practices

Best Practices generated two thematic categories out of 15 key codes. The first category, What We Do, focuses on strategies to raise awareness and program success. The second category, Mentor Suggestion, are based on the mentor's experiences and what they believe

would be an added benefit to their program. Encouragement, Being Available, Workshops and Seminars, and Give Options Base on Interest are among the highest code frequency for What We Do. One mentor stated, “I try to encourage them and be there to support them,” another mentor stated that “the workshops and seminars helps them to focus on one issue at a time,” and another mentor commented that “we allow the girls to sign up for classes that they are interested in.” Group by Age, Invite Experts, and Provide individual resources we frequent under this group as well. One mentor stated, “the school provides social services for major issues.”

Table 4
Content Analysis Results for Relationship Building

Thematic Category	Key Codes	Code frequency	Sample responses
Mentor-Mentee Relationships			Q1. Describe how mentor-mentee relationships are formed?
	Mentor Conscious of girls’ interests	4	Always ask them how they are doing in certain areas that concern them.
	Engaging one another	3	I engage them through conversation and encouragement.
	Demographics	3	Gender, age, and personalities so they can better relate to each other.
	Social stability	2	The volunteers must maintain neutrality and avoid conflict.
	Respect for each other	2	Mutual respect is key to build relationships with each other.
	Seek comfortability	2	The girls are looking for safety, so we try to be as transparent as possible.
	Experienced mentors	1	We screen our volunteer and seek out those with mentoring experience.
	Similar experiences	1	Volunteers are women who grew up in the same areas and schools as the girls
	mentor relationship with head coach [a]	1	As coaches we work together to help the girls set goals for themselves.
Peer Relationships			Q2. How are peer relationships built among girls in the program?
	Mutual goals	4	Grouping them so that they all have the same goals.

Peer group relationships	4	They build relationships their peer groups as well.
Supporting each other	3	Sisterhood- findings thing in common through support.
Learning from each	2	They are intrigued by each other's skills set and want to learn from each other.
Working as a team	2	We identify the stronger girls and pair them with girls who have difficulties.
Taking initiative	1	They tend to take initiate and take the leadership role on their own.

Note. [a] Coach is another term used for mentor. This person oversees and directs the girls in the program.

The thematic category, Mentor Suggestions, was generated from 4 key codes: Consistency, Compassionate Leaders, More Elementary Level Programs, and Push Education. Two of the mentors suggested consistency; one stated, "just being consistent in helping them to grow and develop in their gifts." Other suggestions included "we need mor leaders who understand highs school age girls and you can't be judgmental," "we push education so that our girls can reach their full potential while deciding their career path," and "there should be more programs at the elementary level so the girls can be prepared to compete at the high school level." These were responses from all the mentors when ask if they wanted to add something that was not discussed in the interview. The thematic categories and key code for best practices are presented in Table 5.

Accomplishments

Mentor responses to interview questions regarding accomplishments generated 16 key codes. From the 16 key codes, two thematic categories were identified: Participant Accomplishments, and Program Accomplishments. When asked about the accomplishments of the individuals who participate in the program, one mentors stated that "some of the girls return as mentors and teach other girls how they applied what they learned," another mentor said, "the

program has been instrumental in helping them build their confidence," and one mentor stated that "some of our mentees have gone on to be instructors, self-employed, and freelance artist." These are among to highest code frequency other codes include, taking risks, academic success, pursuing college degree, and having new skills.

Program accomplishments emerged from seven key codes, all pertaining to the accomplishments of the program since it began. One mentor stated that "completing a planned day is an accomplishment because the planning stages come together." Mentee success was

Table 5
Content Analysis Results for Best Practices

Thematic Category	Key Codes	Code frequency	Sample responses
What we do			What strategies do you use to raise awareness and program success?
	Encouragement Being available	5	I try to encourage them and be there to support them.
	Workshops & seminars	3	The workshops and seminars give helps them to focus on one issue at a time.
	Address concerns	3	If necessary, bring awareness of the issues to those responsible for the child.
	Give options based on interest	2	We allow the girls to sign up for class that they are interested in.
	Group sessions by age	2	The girls are group together by their age range so that discussions are relevant.
	Invite experts	2	We invite motivational speakers to our program to help encourage the girls.
	Provide individual resources	2	School provides social services for other major issues.
	Train/Teach//Practice	2	I am trained on how to assess mental health issues, so I use those skills to implement the proper solutions.
	Program collaboration	2	We work with other programs like ours to learn different strategies.
	Educational/cultural field trips	1	We take the girls trips that are educational, cultural, and fun, to help give them balance.
	Community service projects	1	We do service projects at other programs like feeding the homeless.

Mentor suggestions			Is there anything you would like to add concerning mentoring adolescent girls?
	Consistency	2	Just being consistent in helping to them to grow and develop in their girts.
	Compassionate Leaders	1	W need leaders who understand high school girls, and you can't be judgmental.
	More elementary level programs	1	There should be more programs at the elementary level so the girls can be prepared the compete at high school level.
	Push education	1	We push education so that our girls can reach their full potential while deciding their career paths.

among the frequent codes for Program accomplishments, and so was participant increase. One mentor stated that "we have a growing rate of participants." Other program accomplishments included building partner relationships, performing, at more events and recognition awards. One mentor stated, "we are now called on to perform at other games and events that were never a part of," and another mentor said that some of the program accomplishments was "receiving awards and recognition for our work in the community." The thematic categories and key code for accomplishments are presented in Table 6.

Funding

Mentor responses from interview questions regarding funding generated nine key codes and from the nine, two thematic categories were generated. The categories were Program Funding, and Funding requirements. From the mentor's responses Donations and Fundraisers had the most code frequency. One mentor stated, "we receive donations and do fundraisers as well." Another mentor said "we do three dinner fundraiser each year. Other funding sources as indicated by mentors were community sponsors, private sponsor, grants, and budget items. One program state

"we receive private and state grants when they are available." Another mentor said "we solicit sponsorship from businesses and other organization in the community.

Funding requirements was generated out of three key codes. When asked what the requirements are to receive funds, three of the mentors stated "mainly being a not-for-profit, 501c3 organization. 501c3 determination letter is a ruling determination by the Internal Revenue Service that lists a nonprofit organization tax-exempt status. One mentor stated that "presenting a proposal and getting approved" was a require to receive funds and another mentor stated, "the girls that are being sponsored must be active in the group." The thematic categories and key code for funding are presented in Table 7.

Table 6
Content Analysis Results for Accomplishments

Thematic Category	Key Codes	Code frequency	Sample responses
Participant Accomplishments			What are some of the accomplishments of the individuals who participate?
	Return as mentors, and instructors	5	Some of the girls as mentors and to teach other girls how they apply what they learned
	Confidence and self-esteem	5	The program has been instrumental in helping to build their confidence and self-esteem once they see that the can achieve their goals.
	Pursuing college degrees	4	One of our artistic leaders passed auditions to go on and pursue her B.A. in Fine Arts.
	Having new skills	4	New skills throughout the program that they apply to everyday life.
	Earned leadership roles	3	Some of the girls earned leadership roles within the program.
	Entrepreneurship	3	Some of our mentees have gone on to be instructors, self-employed, contract and freelance artist.
	Taking Risks	2	
	Join traveling teams	1	Some girls get invited to join traveling teams
	Academic Success	1	They all completed their grade levels.

Program Accomplishments			What are some of the accomplishments of the program since it began?
	Event completion	3	Completing a planned day is an accomplishment due to the plans phases.
	Mentee success	2	How successful and well-adjusted the girls are when they leave the program
	Participant increase	2	We have a growing rate of participants.
	Building Partner relationships	2	Building comradery and collaboratives with similar organizations.
	Establishing a competition team	1	We have established a competition team, which has never been done in the history of the program.
	Performing at more events	1	We are now called on to perform at other games and events that we were never a part of.
	Recognition awards	1	Receiving awards and recognition for our work in the community.

Table 7

Content Analysis Results for Program Funding Category

Thematic Category	Key Codes	Code frequency	Sample comments
Program funding			Q1. How is the program funded?
	Donations	5	We receive donations as well as do fundraisers.
	Fundraisers	5	So, we do three dinner fundraisers each year.
	In the budget	2	Designated funds are held in an account by the school.
	Community sponsors	2	We solicit sponsorship from business and other organizations in the community.
	Private sponsors	1	There are certain individuals who will sponsors girls in need.
	Grants	1	We receive private and state grants when they are available.
Funding Requirements			Q2. What are the requirements to receive funds?
	501c3 determination letter [a]	2	Mainly being a not-for-profit 501c3 organization.

Proposal Approval	1	Presenting a proposal and getting approved.
Active in group	1	The girls that are being sponsored must be active in the group.

Note. [a] 501c3 determination letter is a ruling determination by the Internal Revenue Service that lists a nonprofit organizations tax-exempt status.

Chapter V

Discussion

In this qualitative study, five mentors from five different mentoring organizations gave their perspective on the effectiveness of mentoring adolescent girls. They were asked a series of questions as relating to (1) the measurement of their program's success; (2) how the program finding is secured; and (3) information regarding strategies that are implemented in their program that can be useful to another adolescent girl mentoring program. The results of this study revealed some commonalities with previous literature pertaining to mentoring adolescent girls as well as some new information. Expanding on previous knowledge, for each of the six themes that were identified, the results of this study hopes to stimulate other research ideas so that mentoring organization for adolescent girls will have information that will assist in implementing successful programs.

Program structure was identified as a theme among all participants responses in the study. All the programs targeted girl within the adolescent age range of 8-18 years old. Some of the programs targeted at-risk girls, whiles others welcomed all races and nationalities. Albright, Hurd, and Hussain (2017) indicated that youth mentoring programs are usually structured to promote better outcomes for marginalized youth. Study participants address pre/post program assessment as a way of knowing for sure that girls have a desire to be a part of the program and can successfully complete the program. All the mentors agree that participant feedback could

help with positive changes in the program; and some mentor responses indicate that volunteers are needed to promote successful outcomes and to prevent unwanted changes.

Social issues resulted as one of the largest categories in the study. All the mentors commented on peer pressure and the need for adolescent girls to fit in. These issues stand out for adolescent girls because they try to find different ways to fit in while dealing with other issues. Some of the other issues may include health and fitness, which is a category within the social issues theme generated from mentor responses to interview questions. Mentors stated that they bring in experts who teach and train in physical and nutrition health. Self-esteem was also identified among the categories of social issues. The mentor's perspectives varied concerning the levels of self-esteem among the girls in their program. Some of the mentors perceive the girls as having low self-esteem because of their environment; and some mentors said their girls were bold and confident on all levels when it comes to being a part of a group.

Beauty influence lead in the social issues' category of this study. When asked questions pertaining to how girls define beauty and what or who influences them the most, all five mentors responded that hair, nails, makeup, clothes, shoes, personal appearance, are how the girls define beauty; and they are most influenced by social media, celebrities, and their peers. The results are a short list of issues that adolescent girl mentoring programs focus on. The broader list indicate that mentoring programs can be beneficial to adolescent girl when implement properly. Youth mentoring program are forms of social and educational intervention that deal with social issues among children and youth for social support (Raithelhuber, 2019).

Relationship building was a theme that most mentors were eager to address. When ask questions regarding mentee-mentor relationships, they responded in ways that emphasized their own personal interactions with the girl in their program. Being conscious of girls' interest,

offering encouragement, and engaging one another were the top codes for the mentee-mentor relationship category. In a previous study on youth mentoring relationships, researchers noted that better performance from youth are associated with the encouragement they receive from adult leaders, and youth become more emotionally engaged in the mentoring relationship (Karcher, Davidson, Rhodes, & Herrera, 2010).

Peer relationships was another category the resulted from the current study. All the mentors stated that grouping the girls together helps in building their relationships with each other because they have common goals and can support each other. theories on gender and adolescent girls' psychological health and development, suggest that adolescent girls have psychosocial needs and ways of relating (Spencer & Liang, 2009); therefore, building both mentor-mentee and peer relationships can produce beneficial outcomes in mentoring programs for adolescent girls.

Best practices described the implementation of the program's format. In other words, this theme gave a description of what and how things are done in the program to produce favorable outcomes from the mentor's perspective. Mentors were also able to add suggestions for implementation based on their own experiences as mentors. Being available as mentors and bringing in experts to teach and train had high code frequencies which suggest that collaborating with other people and sources can help bridge the gap between a successful/non successful program. Jones, Keller, and Wheeler (2011) suggest that mentoring collaborative can increase program goals and enhance the current practices of the program.

Accomplishments was a theme emerged with two categories: (1) participant. and (2) program accomplishments. Based on the mentor's responses to questions regarding accomplishments, a correlation was discovered in some areas of both categories. For example,

mentee success was stated as a program accomplishment, while the participant accomplishments specified areas where the girls have been successful according to the mentor's perspective. Youth mentoring programs play an integral part in positive youth development and are progressively popular in their approach to early intervention (Raposa et al., 2019) with adolescent girls.

Funding was a theme that examined two categories: the type of funding that mentoring programs received, and the requirements for receiving the funds. All the mentors stated that their programs had two common funding types: donations and fundraising. One mentor said that their program received state grants as well. Funding requirements included having a note-for-profit 501c3 ruling letter on file with the Internal Revenue Service and presenting a proposal for approval. Researchers suggest plans for allocating funds should be established so that the mentoring program will function smoothly (Weinberger, 2013). Even if a program can secure grants from government entities, those funds must be used within a specified time frame (Weinberger, 2013) and allocations for those funds should be planned as well.

Strengths and Limitations

Strengths

The strengths of the current study include the qualitative data that was obtained from the participants about their perspectives on the effectiveness of mentoring adolescent girls. The semi-structured interview questions led to a broad range of responses from the mentors, that generated enough themes to identify some effective strategies. Another strength was the approach to not only recruit youth mentors to participate in the study, but program directors as well strengthened the study. The program directors reported more years of experience and gave more information regarding the operations of the mentoring program. With this knowledge the

research was able to show comparable themes like mentor-mentee relationships and program and participant accomplishments. Another strength was the participants reported coming different types of program such as community based, church based, and high school. These differences did not change the generalized perspectives of the mentors regarding the effective strategies of mentoring adolescent girls.

Limitations

The participants in the study were from grassroot organizations located across Chicago's southland area. Coming from these ground-up organizations, the participants of the study could only give limited information because they are growing in their role as mentors as the program grows. The organization with the most years in existence (20 years), was a church-based program that centered all its activities within the realm of the church. The mentor that came from that program was only able to provide knowledge from her four years of experience. Selection bias may have affected the results of this study. The mentor's perspectives may have differed from those of more prominent organizations like Polished Pebbles and Girls Scouts. Those programs may be better equipped to manage a wider range of strategies for mentoring adolescent girls, and their mentors could have offered a broader perspective on how those strategies are implemented.

There is limited research that compares the best practices of well-established youth mentoring programs with grassroot youth mentoring programs. Future research should explore this comparison to show how the difference in program establishment can affect the implementations of its strategies for mentoring adolescent girls.

Conclusions

The objective of this research was to identify the most effective mentoring strategies to combat social issues that adolescent females are faced with; and to explore the implementation of female-only mentoring programs in Chicago's southland communities. The objective was met at the analytical stage of this study which generated codes, and thematic categories to help identify the mentoring strategies from the perspective of the mentors who participated in this study. This study adds to previous research on youth mentoring by providing a rich base of information regarding the effectiveness of mentoring adolescent girls. Several themes emerged from the findings that should be helpful in conducting future qualitative research. The participants in this study achieved consensus in identifying key components of effective mentoring strategies. The key components were comprised of themes that identify the measurement of program success, how program funding is secured, and the implementation of mentoring strategies. Findings can be useful to new and existing youth programs and mentors, and others considering entering the youth mentoring arena. Youth mentoring programs and mentors can evaluate and change their mentoring strategies as needed, thereby improving the program structure to make sure youth development outcomes are successful.

Recommendations

Given the extent to which mentoring can be an effective mechanism in positive youth development (Raposa et al., 21019), this study recommends further research to expand on effective strategies for mentoring adolescent girls. The participants of this study with more experience focused more on the program as a whole, whereas the participants with less experience had a focus on their interactions with the girls who participate in their program. These observations are a good reason to explore the distinctions in youth mentoring. There is limited

research that compares the best practices of well-established youth mentoring programs with grassroot youth mentoring programs. It is recommended that research be conducted to explore this comparison and to show how the difference in program establishment can affect the implementations of its strategies for mentoring adolescent girls.

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Appendices

Appendix A

Interview Questions

Directions:

These questions seek to determine the necessary factors involved in implementing a successful youth mentoring program for adolescent girls. Please answer all questions to your best knowledge giving complete details. After the results are tabulated and compiled, a report of the aggregate data will be produced. Your responses will be treated with strict confidentiality.

1. Where is your program located?
2. What is the basis of your organization?
3. What is your role in the organization?
4. How long have you served in this role?
5. What is the history of your mentoring organization?
6. What is the target papulation of your mentoring organization?
7. What intake assessments do you make before enrolling participants into the program?
8. What post-program assessments do you make after participants complete the program?
9. What are the goals for a participant to complete the program?
10. What social issues concerning adolescent girls do you target in your program?
11. What strategies do you use to raise awareness concerning girl's physical and nutritional health?
12. Describe the self-esteem levels of the girls in your program.
13. How do you combat social issues among adolescent girls such as poverty, teen pregnancy, drugs, gang violence, bullying, and suicide?

14. Describe how the girls in your program define beauty and what influences them the most.
15. What are some of the accomplishments of the individuals who participate or have participated in the program?
16. Describe how the mentor/mentee relationships are formed?
17. What are the factors involved in creating mentor/mentee relationships?
18. How are peer relationships built among the girls in your programs?
19. What would cause the structure of your program to change?
20. What are some of the accomplishments of the program since it began?
21. How is this program funded?
22. What are the requirements for receiving the funds?
23. Is there anything you would like to add that has not already been discussed concerning mentoring adolescent girls?

Appendix B

Permission Request Letter

[Date]

[Name of Director]
[Title]
[Name of Organization]
[Address]
[Address]

Dear [Name of Director]:

As a graduate student in the Public Administration program at Governors State University, I am conducting research as part of the requirements for a Master of Public Administration degree. The title of my research project is, "The Effectiveness of Mentoring Adolescent Girls: Targeting Underserved Communities in Chicago's South Suburbs." The purpose of my research is to measure the effectiveness of youth mentoring programs and to explore the factors involved in implementing a successful female-only mentoring program for adolescent girls.

I am writing to request your permission to conduct my research at [Name of Organization] and to recruit Program Directors/Mentors, to participate in an interview for my research study. If approval is granted, the interview process will last for approximately 60 minutes and will occur at the time agreed upon by the researcher and the participants. Taking part in this study is completely voluntary, and participants are welcome to discontinue participation at any time. Staff members who volunteer to participate will be given consent forms to be signed and returned to the primary researcher (copy attached). The results of the interview will be used for this research project and shared with the participating organizations.

Your approval to conduct this interview will be greatly appreciated. I will be happy to answer any questions or concerns that you may have regarding this research. You may contact me at my email rmiles@student.govst.edu.

If you agree, kindly email me a signed copy of the attached letter of permission on your institution's letterhead acknowledging your consent and permission for me to conduct this interview/study at your organization.

Sincerely,
Robin L. Miles
Principle Investigator

Appendix C

[Your Letterhead]
Site Permission Letter

[Date]

Institutional Review Board
Governors State University
1 University Parkway
University Park, IL 60484

To Whom It May Concern:

Robin L. Miles, a student researcher at Governors State University, College of Arts and Sciences, Public Administration Program has requested permission to conduct the research project named below at [Name of Organization]. I understand that Ms. Miles will recruit Program Directors/Mentors and conduct interviews that will last approximately 60 minutes at a time agreed upon by the researcher and the participant. This letter notifies you that I grant permission for Robin L. Miles to conduct this research at the location listed below, and to interview staff members of [Name of Organization].

Research Project Title: The Effectiveness of Mentoring Adolescent Girls: Targeting underserved Communities in Chicago's South Suburbs

Principal Investigator: Robin L. Miles

Study Site Location: [Name of Organization]
[Address]
[Address}

Permission granted by:

_____
Name of Individual (print) and Title

_____ _____
Name of Individual (Signature) Date

Appendix D

The Effectiveness of Mentoring Adolescent Girls

Informational Letter

[Date]

Dear Participant:

As a graduate student in the Public Administration program at Governors State University, I am conducting research as part of the requirements for the Master degree in Public Administration. The title of my research project is "The Effectiveness of Mentoring Adolescent Girls: Targeting Underserved Communities in Chicago's South Suburbs." The purpose of this research is to measure the effectiveness of youth mentoring programs and to explore the factors involved in implementing a successful female-only mentoring program for adolescent girls. Program directors and mentors who are at least 18 years old are invited to participate.

As part of the research procedures, you will be asked to participate in an interview focusing on your knowledge regarding your program's structure, program goals, success rate of participants, the effects of similarities and differences in mentoring relationships between mentors and mentees, and of their mentoring program. Information from this interview will be used to determine the best practices for female-only youth mentoring programs in the southland area of Chicago. There are no risks involved. The interviews will take approximately 60 minutes to complete. The interviews are anonymous, and no one will know who responded to any of the interview questions. Participation is voluntary. You can refuse to answer any questions at any time and can withdraw without any penalty. Signing the attached letter of consent will validate your participation in the research study.

The professor overseeing this student research study is Mary D. Bruce, Ph. D., Full Professor, College of Arts and Sciences-Public Administration, Governors State University, 1 University Parkway, University Park, Illinois 60484, Office: 708-235-7627 email: mbruce@govst.edu.

Thank you for your assistance in this research study.

Robin Miles
Principal Investigator

Appendix E

Governors State University
1 University Parkway
University Park, IL 60484

Letter of Consent

Protocol Title: The Effectiveness of Mentoring Adolescent Girls: Targeting Underserved Communities in Chicago's South Suburbs

Principal Investigator: Robin L. Miles

Please read this consent document carefully before you decide to participate in this study.

Purpose of the research study: The purpose of this study is to measure the effectiveness of youth mentoring programs and to explore the factors involved in implementing a successful female-only mentoring program for adolescent girls.

Participants: The target participants will be adult program directors/mentors who are at least 18 years of age. The results of the study will be shared with the participating organizations. Consent and participation are voluntary.

What you will be asked to do in the study: Program Directors/Mentors will be asked to participate in an interview focusing on their knowledge regarding program structure, program goals, success rate of participants, and mentoring relationships in their program.

Time required: The interview will last approximately 60 minutes.

Location: The interview will take place at the location where the mentoring program is implemented or a mutually agreed upon location.

Risks and Benefits: The risk factor is minimum risk. Your participation in this study does not involve any physical or emotions risk to you beyond that of normal, everyday life. You will be participating in research that will measure the knowledge of program structure, goals,

success rate of participants, and the effects of mentoring relationships. These are programs which aims to provide recommendations on strategies that would assist anyone desiring to implement female mentoring programs for adolescent girls.

Compensation: Compensation will not be offered to participants. Participation is voluntary.

Confidentiality: Your identity will be kept confidential. Only the researcher will have access to the data**.** All identity will be kept confidential. The signed consent forms and information provided will be kept confidential in a locked file cabinet in the office of May D. Bruce, Ph.D., a Full Professor of Public Administration in the College of Arts and Sciences and the Project Director in room C3341 at Governors State University. All data will be destroyed three years after completion of the study.

Voluntary participation: Your participation in this study is completely voluntary. There is no penalty for not participating. You may also refuse to answer any of the questions asked.

Right to withdraw from the study: If at any time and for any reason, you would prefer not to participate in this study, please feel free not to. If you feel uncomfortable you have the right to withdraw from the study at any time without consequence. If you decide to withdraw from this study, the researchers will ask you if the information already collected from you can be used. You have the right to refuse the use of the collected information without penalty.

Whom to contact if you have questions about the study: Mary D. Bruce, Ph. D., Full Professor, College of Arts and Sciences-Public Administration, Governors State University, 1 University Parkway, University Park, Illinois 60484, Office: 708/235-7627 email: mbruce@govst.edu.

Whom to contact about your rights as a research participant in the study:

If you have questions about this project, you may also contact the GSU Institutional Review Board Chair, Renee Theiss, PhD, at 708-235-2147 or email at irb@govst.edu.

Agreement: I have read the procedure described above. I voluntarily agree to participate in the procedure, and **I have received a copy of this description.**

Participant: _____ Date: _____

Principal Investigator: _____ Date: _____

Appendix F

Sample Excel Coding Table

Code	Participant A	Participant B	Participant C	Participant D	Participant E
Participants Role in Program	Owner, Program Director	Program Director, Mentor, Set up Events	Creative Director, Head Coach, put together events, supervise	Founder, music director, program director, artistic director, youth coach, overseer	Activities coordinator, mentor, youth leader
Years served	14	5	2	13	4
Location	Country Club Hills, South Suburbs Chicago Southside	Homewood	Olympia Fields	South Suburbs, South Side of Chicago, Virtual Programming	Beecher, Illinois
Program Participants	at-risk youth. Ages 8-18	young ladies, ages 13-17, all races and ethnicities	High School girls, ages 14-18	girls, ages 12-18	High school aged youth
Program Structure	Community Based Program, After-school program, summer program, family-oriented program, formed in 2006, 501c3 ruling,	Ministry, empower, encourage, listening ear, skills, started in 2015 as a church sponsored high school project, the church now implement events based on the program	High School, Auxiliary program, Dance Team, originated in the 90's, dismantled in early 2000's and was re-established in 2017 with a new name	Fine Arts, Impoverished Communities, established in 2012 as a not-for profit organization	Church, High School Youth Group, support, existed as long as the church - 20 years for the group
Funding	501c3 ruling Donations Community sponsors state grants private donations	501c3 ruling Donations Church sponsors Community sponsors use of community facilities	Approved proposal Designated funds from school fundraisers parent donations Community donations	donations sponsor fundraisers	Active participation in required group activities donations fundraisers church supporters church supplement

Appendix G

Sample Code List Organization

Intake Assessment

- Commitment (1)
- Expected outcomes (1)
- Experience (1)
- Family dynamics (2)
- Family needs (1)
- Having a desire to participate (4)
- Having a desire to participate
- Having a desire to participate

Participants Role in Program

- Activities coordinator (1)
- Artistic director (1)
- Coach (2)
- Coach
- Creative Director (1)
- Event coordinator (2)
- Event Coordinator
- Mentor (5)
- Mentor
- Mentor
- Mentor
- Mentor
- Music director (1)
- Overseer (1)
- Owner (2)
- Owner
- **Program Director (3)**
- Program Director

Location

- Beecher, Illinois (1)
- Chicago Southside (2)
- Chicago Southside
- Country Club Hills (1)
- Homewood (1)
- Olympia Fields (1)
- South Suburbs (2)
- South Suburbs
- Virtual Programming (1)

Program Structure

- 14 years (1)
- 20 years (1)
- 3 years (1)
- After-school program (1)
- Auxiliary program (1)
- Church (3)
- Church
- Church sponsored event
- Community based program (2)
- Community based program
- Dance team (1)
- Collaborate programs (1)
- Discuss their worth (1)
- Educational cultural fun trips (1)
- Encourage student leadership (1)
- Give options based on interest (2)
- Give options based on interest
- Go to conventions (2)
- Go to workshops
- Group discussion (4)
- Group discussions
- Group discussions
- Group by age
- Invite experts (2)
- Invite motivational speakers
- Listening skills (2)
- Offer
- Parent/guardian awareness (1)
- Provide resources individually (1)
- School provided social services (1)
- Service projects (1)
- Teach bible life application (1)

Peer Relationships

- Afore knowledge of program (1)
- Built by peer group (1)

Appendix H

Sample Code List Categorization

DEMOGRAPHICS
Participants Role in Program

- Activities coordinator (1)
- Artistic director (1)
- Coach (2)
- Creative Director

Mentors #Years served

- 2
- 4
- 5

Location

- Beecher, Illinois (1)
- Chicago Southside (2)
- Country Club Hills (1)

Program Participants

- Ages 8-18
- All races and ethnicities (1)
- At-risk youth (2)

PROGRAM FUNDING
Funding

- Use of community facilities (1)
- State grants (1)
- Private sponsors (1)
- Part of school budget (1)
- Fundraisers (3)
- Donations (7)

MENTORING RELATIONSHIPS
Mentor-Mentee Relationships

- Age (1)
- Background checks required (1)
- Base on youth needs (1)
- Encouragement (1)
- Engaging one another (2)
- Interest conscious (3)
- Personalities (1)
- to mentor (1)

Peer Relationships

- Afore knowledge of program (1)
- Built by peer group (1)
- Enjoying each other (2)
- Gravitate to other's skill set (1)
- (2)

PROGRAM STRUCTURE
Intake Assessment

- Commitment (1)
- Expected outcomes (1)
- Experience (1)
- School behavioral compliance (1)
- Talent (1)

Reasons for Program Change

- Number of participants (1)
- Called by different entities (1)
- Having Full-time leaders (1))
- Growth (1)
- (1)

Post Assessments

- Character assessment (1)
- Continue
- (1)

Best Practices

- Address concerns (1)
- Be available (1)
- Check on progress
- Collaborate

SOCIAL ISSUIES
Social Issues

- Academics (1)
- Behavioral problems (1)
- Being themselves (1)
- Bullying (2)

- Confidence (1)

Health & Fitness practices

- Assess training needs (1)
- Bring in experts (3)
- Implement healthy eating (1)
- Information pamphlets (1)
- Join Food Depository (1)

Levels of Self-esteem

- Bold (1)
- Confidence in the program (1)
- Defensive (1)
- Experience lack (1)

Beauty Influences

- Apparel (1)
- Beauty in humor (1)

ACCOMPLISHMENTS PARTICIPANT Accomplishments

- Become instructors (1)
- Better understanding of self (1)
- Building self-esteem (1)
- Contract entrepreneurs (1)
- Earned leadership roles (1)
- Freelance artists (1)
- confidence (1)
- Having new skills (1)
- Join
- **Program Accomplishments**
- Bringing in more clients
- Building relationships with similar organizations
- Completing
- situations
- Teaching with relevance

***Key Code.**
The lists of codes were reduced and consolidated, then categorized into color coded labeled clusters.

Codes highlighted in turquoise are in the Demographics category.

Codes highlighted in green are in the Funding category.

Codes highlighted in red are in the Mentoring Relationships category.

Codes highlighted in yellow are in the Program Structure category.

Codes highlighted in purple are in the Social Issues category.

Codes highlighted in blue are in the Accomplishments category.